“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 1

The Supreme Principle of the Guru

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I worship the gurus, the devotees of the Lord, the Lord’s avatāras, His manifestations and His potencies, and the Lord Himself, who is known as Kṛṣṇa Caitanya.

2 I worship Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya and Nityānanda, who have risen together like the sun and the moon on the eastern horizon of Gauḍa. Wondrous and bestowing auspiciousness, They dispel the darkness.

3 What the Upaniṣads call the non-dual Brahman is only the radiance of His body. The one called the Puruṣa, the Supersoul dwelling within all, is His plenary expansion. And Bhagavān, full of the six opulences, is He Himself. In this world there is no Supreme Truth higher than Caitanya, who is Kṛṣṇa.

4 “Out of mercy He has descended in the age of Kali to bestow what had not been given for a long time: the treasure of devotion to Himself, rich in the most exalted and radiant *rasa* of divine love. May that Lord Hari, the son of Śacī, resplendent with a mass of radiance more beautiful than gold, ever shine in the cave of your heart.” (Vidagdha-mādhava 1.2)

5 “Rādhā is the transformation of love for Kṛṣṇa; She is His pleasure-giving potency (*hlādinī śakti*). Therefore, although Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa are one in soul, long ago They assumed separate forms on earth. Now the two

have become one and appeared as Caitanya. I bow to Him, who is Kṛṣṇa Himself, adorned with Rādhā's emotion and radiance." (Svarūpa Dāmodara's diary)

6 "How great is Śrī Rādhā's love? What is My own wondrous sweetness, which She alone relishes through that love? And what happiness does She feel when She realizes Me?" Longing to know this, the moon Hari, rich with Her emotion, was born from the ocean of Śacī's womb.

7 Saṅkarṣaṇa, Kāraṇodakaśāyī, Garbhodakaśāyī, Kṣīrodakaśāyī and Śeṣa are His portions and the parts of His portions. May that Rāma who is called Nityānanda be my shelter.

8 Beyond māyā lies the all-pervading realm of Vaikuṇṭha, full of every opulence. There, among the four divine vyūhas, His form called Saṅkarṣaṇa shines forth. I surrender to that Śrī Nityānanda-Rāma.

9 The blessed Puruṣa, the original Lord and the master of māyā, whose body shelters countless universes, lies in person in the midst of the Causal Ocean. He is one portion of Nityānanda. I surrender to that Śrī Nityānanda-Rāma.

10 "The blessed Garbhodakaśāyī is a portion of His portion. The lotus from His navel has a stem that holds the multitude of worlds, and it is the birthplace of Brahmā, the creator of the worlds. I surrender to that Śrī Nityānanda-Rāma."

11 "Viṣṇu who lies in the Ocean of Milk, the Supersoul and maintainer of all beings, is a portion of a portion of His portion. Ananta, who upholds the earth, is also His part. I surrender to that Śrī Nityānanda-Rāma."

12 Mahā-Viṣṇu, the creator of the world, creates this universe through His energy, māyā. The Lord Advaita Ācārya is His very avatāra.

13 He is called Advaita because He is non-different from Hari, and Ācārya because He proclaims devotion (*bhakti*). I take shelter of that Lord, Advaita Ācārya, who descended as a devotee.

14 “I bow to Kṛṣṇa, who comprises the five truths (Pañca-tattva). He appears in the form of a devotee, in the identity of a devotee, as the avatāra of a devotee, as the one called a devotee, and as the devotional potency.”

15 All glory to the most merciful Rādhā and Madana-mohana! They are the refuge of me, who am lame and of little intelligence, and Their lotus feet are my all in all.

16 In resplendent Vṛndāvana, beneath a wish-fulfilling tree, Śrī Śrī Rādhā and Śrīla Govinda-deva sit on a throne in a splendid jewelled temple, and Their dearest companions serve Them. I remember Them.

17 Beautiful Śrī Gopīnātha began the sweet *rasa* of the rāsa dance. He stands on the riverbank at Vaṁśīvaṭa and draws the gopīs with the sound of His flute. May He bestow His blessings upon us.

18 All glory, all glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaita-candra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

19 These three Deities have made the Gauḍīya Vaiṣṇavas Their own. I worship the feet of these three, for these three are my masters.

20 At the beginning of this book I offer the auspicious invocation (*maṅgalācaraṇa*) by remembering three: the guru, the Vaiṣṇavas and the Lord.

21 Remembering these three destroys every obstacle, and one’s own desires are easily fulfilled.

22 That invocation is of three kinds: defining the subject, giving a blessing and offering obeisances.

23 In the first two verses I offer obeisances to the worshipful Lord. These are of two kinds: general and particular.

24 In the third verse I define the subject, and from it one can know the identity of the Supreme Truth.

25 In the fourth verse I bless the world, praying that the mercy of Kṛṣṇa Caitanya may reach everywhere.

26 In that verse I also state the external reason for His descent. In the fifth and sixth verses I state its root purpose.

27 These six verses describe the truth of Kṛṣṇa Caitanya. The next five verses describe the greatness of Nityānanda.

28 The next two verses give an account of the truth of Advaita, and one more verse explains the Pañca-tattva.

29 With these fourteen verses I offer the invocation, and within them I describe the whole subject.

30 Offering obeisances to all the Vaiṣṇavas who are listening, I shall now examine the meaning of all these verses.

31 O Vaiṣṇavas, all of you, listen with undivided attention to how the scriptures establish the truth of Caitanya, who is Kṛṣṇa.

32 The Lord enjoys His pastimes in six forms: as Kṛṣṇa Himself, as the two kinds of guru, as the devotees, as the avatāras, as His manifestations and as His potencies.

33 I worship the feet of these six truths. First I offer the invocation in a general way.

34 I worship the gurus, the devotees of the Lord, the Lord's avatāras, His manifestations and His potencies, and the Lord Himself, who is known as Kṛṣṇa Caitanya.

35 First I worship the feet of my initiating guru and of all my instructing gurus.

36 Śrī Rūpa, Sanātana, Raghunātha Bhaṭṭa, Śrī Jīva, Gopāla Bhaṭṭa and Raghunātha Dāsa —

37 these six are my instructing gurus. I offer ten million obeisances at the lotus feet of them all.

38 Śrīvāsa is the chief of all the devotees of the Lord. I offer thousands of obeisances at their lotus feet.

39 Advaita Ācārya is a partial avatāra of the Lord. I offer ten million obeisances at His lotus feet.

40 Nityānanda Rāya is the manifestation of the Lord's own form (*svarūpa-prakāśa*). I worship the lotus feet of Him whose servant I am.

41 Gadādhara Paṇḍita and the others are the Lord's own potencies. I offer thousands of obeisances at the feet of them all.

42 Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Prabhu is the Supreme Lord Himself (*svayaṁ bhagavān*). I offer endless obeisances at His lotus feet.

43 Having offered obeisances to the Lord together with His associates, I shall now consider how He is present in these six.

44 Although my guru is a servant of Caitanya, I know him to be His manifestation.

45 The scriptures testify that the guru is a form of Kṛṣṇa. In the form of the guru, Kṛṣṇa shows mercy to His devotees.

46 "One should know the ācārya as Me and never disrespect him. One should not envy him, thinking him an ordinary mortal, for the guru embodies all the gods." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.17.27)

47 I know the instructing guru to be Kṛṣṇa's own form. He appears in two forms: as the indwelling Supersoul and as the best of devotees.

48 "O Lord, even with a lifespan as long as Brahmā's the wise cannot repay their debt to You, though they remember Your kindness with ever-growing joy. For You dispel the misfortune of embodied beings from within and from without, and in the forms of the ācārya and the Supersoul You reveal the way to Yourself." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.29.6)

49 "To those who are always united with Me and worship Me with love, I give the understanding by which they come to Me." (Bhagavad-gītā 10.10)

50 "Just as the Lord Himself instructed Brahmā and made him realize the truth."

51 "Accept from Me the most confidential knowledge of Myself, endowed with realization, together with its mystery and its auxiliary part, as I now speak it." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.9.31)

52 "By My grace, may you realize in truth exactly how great I am, what My nature is, and what My form, qualities and deeds are." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.9.32)

53 “Before creation I alone existed; there was nothing else, neither effect nor cause, nor what lies beyond them. After creation I exist, and all this creation too is I. And what remains at the end, that am I.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.9.33)

54 “Whatever appears apart from Me, the Reality, and whatever does not appear in Me, know that to be My māyā; it is like a reflection and like darkness.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.9.34)

55 “As the great elements have entered all beings, great and small, and yet have not entered them, so I am within them and yet not within them.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.9.35)

56 “One who seeks the truth of the Supreme Self should inquire into this alone, by direct and indirect means: that which exists everywhere and always.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.9.36)

57 “Glory to Cintāmaṇi, and glory to Somagiri, my guru! Glory to my instructing guru, the Lord whose crown bears a peacock feather. At the tips of His feet, which are like the tender leaves of a wish-fulfilling tree, Jayaśrī (Śrī Rādhā) relishes the *rasa* of choosing Him as Her beloved in play.” (Kṛṣṇa-karṇāmṛta)

58 As the guru within (*caitya-guru*), the Lord is not directly visible to the soul. Therefore Kṛṣṇa becomes the instructing guru in the form of a great devotee.

59 “Therefore an intelligent person should give up bad company and associate with saints. With their words the saints cut away the attachments of his mind.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.26.26)

60 “In the association of saints, discussions of My power become narrations that delight the heart and the ear. By relishing them one quickly

advances on the path of liberation: faith, *rati* and devotion follow one after another." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 3.25.25)

61 The devotee is the very form of the Lord, for he is the Lord's abode. Kṛṣṇa always rests in the heart of His devotee.

62 "The saints are My heart, and I am the heart of the saints. They know nothing but Me, and I know nothing but them, not even a little." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 9.4.68)

63 "My lord, devotees like you are themselves holy places. Through the Lord who holds the club and dwells in their hearts, they make even the holy places holy." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.13.10)

64 These devotees are of two kinds: the Lord's eternal associates and the practitioners (*sādhakas*).

65–66 The avatāras of the Lord are of three kinds: partial avatāras, guṇa-avatāras, who preside over the modes of nature, and, third, empowered avatāras (*śaktyāveśa*). The partial avatāras are the Puruṣas, Matsya and all the others.

67 I count Brahmā, Viṣṇu and Śiva as the three guṇa-avatāras. The empowered avatāras are Sanaka and his brothers, Pṛthu and the sage Vyāsa.

68 The Lord manifests Himself in two ways: one is called *prakāśa* (manifestation), the other *vilāsa* (pastime form).

69–70 When one and the same form appears as many, without any difference in appearance and with a single identity, this is called Kṛṣṇa's principal prakāśa. So He appeared when He married the queens and when He performed the rāsa dance.

71 “How wonderful it is that with one body the Lord alone married sixteen thousand women at the same time, each separately in her own palace!” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.69.2)

72 “The festival of the rāsa dance began, adorned by the circle of gopīs. Kṛṣṇa, the master of yoga, appeared between each two of them.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.33.3)

73–74 “He entered between them and held each by the neck, so that every gopī thought He was beside her alone. Then the sky was crowded with hundreds of airships of the gods and their wives, whose minds were carried away by eagerness. Kettledrums sounded, and showers of flowers fell.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.33.3–4)

75 “When one form appears in many places at one time and is identical in every respect, it is called a prakāśa.” (Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta 1.21)

76 But when one and the same form appears as many manifestations that differ in appearance, this is called vilāsa.

77 “When the Lord, for His pastimes, manifests a form of different appearance, almost equal to Himself in power, that form is called a vilāsa.” (Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta 1.15)

78 Examples are Baladeva, Nārāyaṇa in the spiritual sky, and Vāsudeva, Saṅkarṣaṇa, Pradyumna and the others.

79–80 The Lord’s potencies are of three kinds: the goddesses of fortune (Lakṣmīs), the queens in Dvārakā, and the gopīs in Vraja. The gopīs are the foremost of all, for the son of the king of Vraja is the Supreme Lord Himself.

81 These potencies are bodily expansions (*kāya-vyūha*) of Kṛṣṇa, the original form of the Lord, and they are equal to Him. Together with the devotees they form His entourage.

82 Thus I have worshipped them all in order, beginning with the devotees. Worship of them all is the cause of every good fortune.

83 The first verse is a general invocation. In the second verse I offer worship in particular.

84 I worship Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya and Nityānanda, who have risen together like the sun and the moon on the eastern horizon of Gauḍa. Wondrous and bestowing auspiciousness, They dispel the darkness.

85–86 Kṛṣṇa and Balarāma formerly sported in Vraja, and Their effulgence surpasses ten million suns and moons. Becoming merciful to the world, these two have risen on the eastern horizon of the land of Gauḍa.

87 They are Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya and Nityānanda Prabhu, whose appearance has filled the whole world with joy.

88–89 The sun and moon remove all darkness, reveal things, and so allow dharma to spread. In the same way the two brothers have destroyed the darkness of the souls' ignorance and given them the Absolute Reality.

90 I call this darkness of ignorance "cheating" (*kaitava*). It is the whole range of desires for religious merit (*dharma*), wealth and pleasure.

91 "In this beautiful *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*, composed by the great sage, the supreme dharma is set forth for saints free from envy, and every kind of cheating is cast out of it. Here the true Reality is to be known, which bestows the highest good and uproots the threefold miseries. What need is

there of other scriptures? As soon as the fortunate wish to hear it, the Lord is captured in their hearts." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.1.2)

92 Among these the desire for liberation is the chief cheating, for it makes devotion to Kṛṣṇa vanish.

93 "By the prefix *pra-* even the intention to attain liberation is rejected." (Śrīdhara Svāmī, Bhāvārtha-dīpikā 1.1.2)

94 All action, auspicious and inauspicious, is an obstacle to devotion to Kṛṣṇa. It too belongs to the soul's darkness of ignorance.

95 By the mercy of these two brothers this darkness is destroyed. Having destroyed the darkness, They reveal the truth.

96 The Absolute Reality is Kṛṣṇa, devotion to Kṛṣṇa in the form of love (*prema*), and the congregational chanting of the Holy Name. All of it is bliss itself.

97 The sun and moon destroy external darkness and reveal external objects such as pots and cloth.

98 But the two brothers wash away the darkness of the heart and bring one to meet the two bhāgavatas.

99 One bhāgavata is the great scripture, the *Bhāgavatam*. The other bhāgavata is the devotee, a vessel of the *rasa* of devotion.

100 Through the two bhāgavatas They give the rasa of devotion. Then the Lord, dwelling in the devotee's heart, is subdued by his love.

101 One wonder is that both appear at the same time. Another wonder is that They destroy the darkness in the cave of the heart.

102 This moon and this sun are supremely merciful. By the good fortune of the world They have risen in Gauḍa.

103 I worship the feet of these two Lords. This destroys every obstacle and fulfils one's cherished desires.

104 In these two verses I have offered auspicious worship. Now listen, everyone, to the meaning of the third verse.

105 There is much to be said, but I fear the book would grow too long. So I do not describe it in detail; I tell the essential meaning in few words.

106 "Speech that is brief and essential is true eloquence."

107 Hearing this removes ignorance and the other faults of the heart. One will gain deep love for Kṛṣṇa and find true satisfaction.

108–109 After careful consideration I have written separately of the greatness of Śrī Caitanya, Nityānanda and Advaita, and of the truth of Their devotees, of devotion, of the Holy Name, of love and of rasa. By hearing this, one will know the whole essence of the truth of the Absolute Reality.

110 Ever hoping for the mercy of the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate *Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.